Across Jammu and Kashmir, communal polarisation between the Muslim-dominated valley and the Hindu-dominated Jammu had become a way of life. Before the 1975 accord, Abdullah had headed the Plebiscite Front that was known to receive funds from Pakistan and opposed the state's accession into the Indian Union. However, with the Al-Fatah gone, the anti-Congress opposition space in the valley was now occupied by the Jamaat-e-Islami and by the Jana Sangh in Jammu. When Abdullah was freed from prison following the 1975 accord, the state's Congress Chief Minister, Syed Mir Qasim, resigned on 23 February 1975. He was soon replaced by Abdullah; he was now an almost one-man government supported by his long-time associate, Mirza Afzal Beg. Within months of becoming the Chief Minister, Abdullah, sensing the political winds blowing against Indira Gandhi, began to articulate his misgivings about the accord.

The 1975 Accord

Abdullah had killed two birds with this accord—he was back in power and the cadres of Al-Fatah had been pardoned. Zahgir, despite being tried for both murder and sedition, was released but certain key players like Fazl-ul-Haq Qureshi, Nazir Ahmad Wani, Hamidullah Bhat, Mohammad Shaban Vakil and Farooq Ahmad Bhat had rejected the deal.[2] Despite holding out, Qureshi struck his own deal with Abdullah's new government and was reinstated in his old government job, in 1980. This underscored the influence that both Abdullah and Beg exercised over Qureshi. Mirza Afzal Beg had faithfully protected his boys and delivered them their freedom.

With Abdullah in power, Al-Fatah lost its relevance but held on to the ethos and passion with which they functioned. Abdullah's return to mainstream politics had obviated, for some time, the necessity for organisations like the Master Cell and Al-Fatah. It is interesting that till 1975, the National Conference had used mainstream politics to attract agitated youth and then dispatched them into the twilight zone inhabited by the Master Cell and Al-Fatah. Pakistan, because of its own internal turmoil, was unsure of what position to take on Kashmir.